‘Bunot, The Forgotten Lake of San Pablo’

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Researchers:
Bernardino, Geremi Carl K.
Espiritu, Heart Ashley S.
Magno, Eunisse Stell T.
Untiveros, Princess E.

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Introduction

Lake Bunot is a volcanic crater lake and is one of the Seven Lakes of San Pablo City in the Philippines. Situated in Brgy. Concepcion, San Pablo City, it is hardly five kilometers away from the suburbs that is circular in shape with a regular shoreline, area of 29.6 hectares, a maximum depth of 23 meters and a minimum depth of 15 meters. It has a calculated volume of water in storage of 3.5 million cubic meters. Its outlet at the southern end and an inlet at the northern part water a small area of domesticated coconut plots. Only 4.5 kilometres from the city proper, Bunot is known for its cultured tilapia and fish pens for fingerlings. Its name 'Bunot' came from the old folklore and legends that spanish troops were once exploring the lake and had asked a person husking coconuts what the lake was called and they answered 'Bunot'. The lake has been said to be a place for fish pens but not for relaxation or enjoying the scenery as it required people to ask permission as the area surrounding the lake is owned by residents.

Problem Statement

Bunot Lake, one of the seven crater lakes in San Pablo City, Laguna, faces serious environmental and socio-economic challenges. It is regarded as the most polluted among the seven lakes due to the excessive number of fish pens and the proliferation of informal settlements along its shores. The lake's fish cages far exceed its ecological carrying capacity, resulting in nutrient overloading, oxygen depletion, and frequent fish kills. Furthermore, many households near the lake lack access to proper waste disposal systems, leading to the direct dumping of domestic waste into the water and significantly degrading its quality.

Water samples from the lake have shown high concentrations of fecal coliform bacteria, indicating severe contamination. This situation poses major health risks to the local population and threatens the lake's aquatic ecosystem. Fisherfolk and aquaculture operators suffer the most from these conditions, as water pollution disrupts fish production and undermines their livelihoods. Residents of the informal settlements are exposed to daily health hazards due to poor sanitation and contaminated water. In addition, the lake's environmental decline diminishes its potential for tourism and recreational activities, affecting the broader community.

The risk is further heightened by the area's vulnerability to natural disasters. Many houses around Bunot Lake are built extremely close to the shoreline, with little to no protection against flooding. During typhoons, these structures are at high risk of being damaged or destroyed by rising water levels and strong winds. Families living in these areas face the constant threat of property loss, injury, or even death, especially in the absence of proper infrastructure or disaster preparedness.
Despite its proximity to the city center and its historical value in local aquaculture, Bunot Lake has not received the same level of attention as other lakes such as Sampaloc. Local authorities and environmental agencies struggle to implement effective policies due to limited resources and the complex social dynamics surrounding informal settlements. Without comprehensive and sustained efforts, both the environmental health of Bunot Lake and the safety of the communities around it will continue to decline

Analysis

Studies show that Bunot Lake is the most overlooked lake among the seven (7) Lakes of San Pablo City, Laguna. Bunot Lake is the most critical in terms of water quality, the researchers chose this as a subject based on these observations along with the experiences of the residents that reside around the lake and the amount of wastes from the nearby residential areas that greatly affect the livelihoods of those that uses the lake as a source of income.

Conclusion

The case study of Bunot Lake highlights important environmental and social issues related to the lake, especially concerning water quality and human impact. Even though it is a unique volcanic crater lake, it is often ignored compared to other lakes in San Pablo City. This neglect is concerning because clean water is vital for the ecosystem and for local residents who rely on the lake for their livelihoods, such as fish farming.

The research shows that people living near Bunot Lake are struggling due to pollution from nearby houses. The waste flowing into the lake damages its environment and harms those who rely on its resources. There is a clear need for the community to take responsibility for caring for the lake, as current rules limit public access, preventing it from becoming a beautiful spot for relaxation and enjoyment.

In conclusion the study highlights the need for effective management plans that protect the environment and involve the community. By improving the water quality and fostering responsible stewardship among residents and local authorities, the Bunot lake can be transformed from neglected resource into a sustainable ecological and economic asset for San Pablo city. Future efforts should prioritized managing pollution, educating the community, and creating access policies that support both conservation and tourism.

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